VELLUM PRESS

HEALTH & NUTRITION

Weeknight Table

Meal prep that holds up



A DIGITAL GUIDE

Weeknight Table

Weeknight Table is a cooking system: one short Sunday prep, building blocks that recombine, and recipes with storage notes. It is ordinary food, not a medical meal plan.

If a clinician has given you a diet, use that diet. Use this guide only for the logistics of when the cooking happens.

> Health disclaimer. This guide is education for adults. It is not medical advice, diagnosis, or a treatment plan, and it does not replace a physician, registered dietitian, or qualified coach. Bodies differ. Talk with a licensed clinician before you change how you eat or train, especially if you are pregnant, under 18, injured, managing an illness, or have a history of disordered eating. Stop and seek care for chest pain, fainting, or pain that is sharp, swelling, or unexplained. If you are in crisis in the United States, call or text 988.

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01

How to use this guide

Cook the Sunday sequence once before you try to be clever. The first week teaches the clock. The recipes come after you trust that ninety minutes is enough. If you cook for one, use the one-person cut in the prep chapter instead of storing a family tray you will throw out.

- Read the food-safety table before you store anything.
- Pick two sauces, not five.
- Leave one dinner unplanned.
- Judge the system on Thursday, when hope has worn off.

> **Try this.** Set a timer for ninety minutes including cleanup. When it rings, you stop chopping.

02

The 90-minute Sunday prep

Minute 0 to 10: start the grain or potatoes, and heat the oven. Minute 10 to 35: sheet-pan vegetables with oil and salt, in the oven. Minute 15 to 45: the protein, on another tray or in a pot. Minute 45 to 70: one sauce, and a jar of something crunchy if you have it. Minute 70 to 90: cool, portion, wash up.

Cool food before you lid it. Put sauces where you can see them. Label the day. The one-person cut is half the protein, half the grain, and one sheet of vegetables. You are not required to eat the same bowl five times. You are required to have parts.

Block	Default	One-person cut	Holds
Protein	Tray of thighs or a pot of lentils	Half	3 to 4 days, or freeze
Starch	Rice, farro, or potatoes	Four portions	3 to 4 days
Vegetables	One hot sheet pan	One pan	3 to 4 days
Sauce	One jar	One small jar	3 to 4 days

03

Building blocks that recombine

A block is cooked plain enough to accept a sauce later. Salt it. Do not bury it in a single flavor on Sunday or Wednesday will taste like a compromise. Chicken thighs are done when a food thermometer in the thickest part reads 165°F (74°C). USDA's leftovers page does not treat color as the test. Lentils simmered in salted water, tofu pressed and baked, and canned fish kept for the night you do not want to reheat anything all count as blocks.

Vegetables that hold their shape are better prep citizens than delicate salads. Cabbage, broccoli, peppers, carrots, and onions survive a reheating. Dress greens the day you eat them. A limp dressed salad is why people say prep does not work.

- Salt early. Pale food will not be saved by a sauce you forget to make.
- Keep one raw option: carrots, cucumber, or an apple.
- Freeze a portion on Sunday if you already know Friday is unlikely.
- Eggs still count as protein when the tray runs out.

04

Sauces that rescue leftovers

A sauce is how the same chicken becomes two dinners. Make them in a jar. Thin with a spoon of water if they tighten in the fridge. Taste for salt before you blame the protein.

Sauce	Base	Add	Good on
Yogurt herb	Plain yogurt	Salt, lemon, chopped herbs	Chicken, potatoes, greens
Chili lime	Oil and lime	Chili, garlic, salt	Tofu, cabbage, fish
Tomato simmer	Crushed tomato	Onion, oregano	Lentils, eggs, beans
Peanut	Peanut butter	Soy sauce, vinegar, hot water	Tofu, broccoli, rice

You need two. The third sauce is how Sunday becomes a project. If you hate yogurt, skip it. A sauce you will not eat is not a system.

> **Try this.** Write the sauce name on the jar lid. Future you, standing in the fridge light, is not a careful reader.

05

A four-week rotation

Repeat the shape of the week and rotate the blocks. Week A is chicken and rice. Week B is lentils and potatoes. Week C is tofu and farro. Week D is fish or eggs and whatever vegetable is cheap. The sauces swap so Week A does not taste like last Week A.

Week	Protein	Starch	Sauce	Unplanned dinner
A	Chicken thighs	Rice	Yogurt herb	Friday
B	Lentils	Potatoes	Tomato	Wednesday
C	Baked tofu	Farro or rice	Peanut	Saturday
D	Fish or eggs	Bread or potato	Chili lime	Thursday

If a week collapses, repeat it. Novelty is not the goal. A rotation you can shop from memory is the goal.

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06

Eight recipes

Sheet-pan chicken and cabbage

Heat the oven to 425°F (220°C). Toss chicken thighs with salt and oil. Toss sliced cabbage and onion the same way on the other half of the pan. Roast about 30 to 35 minutes, until a thermometer in the thickest part of the chicken reads 165°F (74°C) and the cabbage has dark edges. Rest five minutes. Four servings. Fridge: 3 to 4 days.

Lentils with tomato and greens

Simmer 1 cup dry lentils in salted water until tender, about 20 minutes. Drain. Warm crushed tomato with garlic and a pinch of chili, then fold in the lentils and a handful of spinach until it wilts. Finish with vinegar. Four servings. Fridge: 3 to 4 days.

Baked tofu

Press tofu for 15 minutes. Tear it into chunks so the edges crisp. Toss with salt and oil. Bake at 425°F until the edges color, about 25 minutes. Sauce it later, not now. Three servings. Fridge: 3 to 4 days.

Yogurt herb sauce and chili lime

Stir yogurt with salt, lemon, and herbs. Separately, shake oil, lime, salt, garlic, and chili. Keep both 3 to 4 days. Use on any block.

Rice or farro, plainly

Rinse rice. Simmer in salted water until tender. Farro takes longer and likes a generous pot. Spread on a tray to cool before you box it. Four to six servings. Fridge: 3 to 4 days. Freeze what you will not eat in that window.

Peanut noodles with leftover vegetables

Boil noodles. Thin peanut butter with hot water, soy sauce, and vinegar. Toss with noodles and chopped leftover vegetables. Add tofu if you have it. Two servings. Best the day you make it.

Egg fried rice, honestly

Cold rice in a hot pan with oil. Scramble in two eggs. Add frozen peas or leftover vegetables. Soy sauce at the end. This is a use-it-up dinner, not a new prep. One or two servings.

Bean toast

Warm white beans with olive oil, garlic, and chili. Pile on toast with a squeeze of lemon and a handful of greens. Ten minutes. One serving. The beans keep 3 to 4 days.

> Times assume a working oven. Poultry is done at 165°F (74°C) in the thickest part, measured with a food thermometer. USDA's leftovers page does not treat color as the test. When you cannot measure, do not serve the chicken.

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07

Shopping, storage, and safety

Write the list in the order of the store: plants, protein, dairy, dry goods. Buy the vegetables you have cooked before. If thighs cost more than the week can bear, buy eggs or lentils instead and keep the plate.

Food	Fridge	Freeze	Reheat
Cooked poultry	3 to 4 days	3 to 4 months	165°F (74°C)
Cooked lentils and grains	3 to 4 days	3 to 4 months	165°F (74°C)
Sauce, including dairy	3 to 4 days	Not the plan	165°F, or boil
Cut raw vegetables	Use while crisp	Not the plan	Cook or eat cold

• Fridge at or below 40°F (4°C).

• Refrigerate perishable food within 2 hours, or within 1 hour if the room is above 90°F (32°C).

• Cool in a shallow container, then lid it. Do not leave a large pot on the counter to cool for hours.

• Reheat leftovers to 165°F (74°C). Sauces and soups can come to a rolling boil.

• If it smells wrong, discard it. Smell is not a substitute for the time and temperature limits.

• These lines follow USDA leftover guidance checked in October 2026. Frozen leftovers can stay safe longer than 3 to 4 months; quality is what drops. If a local authority is stricter, follow that.

08

Cooking on a tighter budget

The expensive failure is food you throw away, not the dried lentils. Cook the amount you will eat. Use cabbage, carrots, oats, eggs, canned tomatoes, peanut butter, and dried beans as the spine. Meat is a flavor and a protein, not the requirement for every dinner.

A cheaper week is still the same shape: protein, starch, plants, sauce. Swap chicken for eggs two nights. Use canned fish once. Buy the store brand of yogurt. The rotation still holds.

- [ ] I shopped from the blocks, not from a craving list.
- [ ] I froze the portion I will not eat within 3 to 4 days.
- [ ] I used one sauce I already like.
- [ ] I left one dinner unplanned so the plan can bend.

> **Try this.** Price the protein per serving once. After that, you will stop being surprised in the aisle.

09

A worked example

B cooks for himself and a partner who gets home late. The first Sunday he tried to make four recipes and a new salad. The timer hit ninety minutes with the sink full and the sauce unmade. Thursday, half the vegetables were soft and they ordered food. That is the failure this system is designed around.

The second Sunday he cooked thighs, rice, a tray of cabbage, and the yogurt sauce. He froze two portions of rice the same night. Monday was a bowl. Tuesday was tacos only in the sense that the cabbage and chicken met a tortilla. Wednesday used the chili-lime he mixed in ten minutes. Thursday the fridge was almost empty, which was the point.

The one-person cut matters when the partner travels. He cooks half the protein and still makes a full sauce, because sauce is what makes the second dinner different. He shops with the list in store order and swaps eggs in when thighs are priced like a holiday.

A month later the rotation is boring in the way a good tool is boring. He can say what is for dinner without a decision. The unplanned night is Wednesday, written down, so a friend can claim it. Food safety is a card on the fridge: 3 to 4 days, then freezer or trash. Nothing in this story is a medical diet. It is a clock and a fridge that stay honest.

If your week does not look like this one, do not force the resemblance. Copy the structure: a baseline, one change at a time, a written review, and a stop when the tool is the wrong tool. The names above are teaching composites, not testimonials and not promises.

10

Field pages

A prep system fails in the grocery aisle and in the fridge, not in the recipe. Fill this before you shop, then again on Thursday.

This week's blocks

Block	What I will cook	Amount	Day it must be eaten by
Protein			
Starch			
Vegetables			
Sauce			
Raw option			

Shopping list in store order

Aisle	Item	Got it
Produce		
Produce		
Protein		
Protein		
Dairy		
Dry goods		
Freezer		

Thursday test

- ☐ I ate the food I prepped.
- ☐ Assembly took under twenty minutes.
- ☐ Nothing important was thrown out.
- ☐ If something was thrown out, next week I will cook less of it.
- ☐ One dinner stayed unplanned.

11

Thirty-day log

This log is the part you write. Print it. A guide you only read is a brochure. Thirty lines is a month, and a month is long enough to see whether the method fits.

Days 1 to 15

Day	Meal one	Meal two	Used prep?	Threw out?	Note
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					

Day	Meal one	Meal two	Used prep?	Threw out?	Note
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					
15					

Do not backfill a day you forgot. Leave it blank. A blank line is more useful next month than a number you invented. The lines are tall enough to write in, not just to type a checkmark.

Days 16 to 30

Day	Meal one	Meal two	Used prep?	Threw out?	Note
16					
17					
18					
19					
20					
21					
22					
23					
24					
25					
26					
27					
28					
29					

Day	Meal one	Meal two	Used prep?	Threw out?	Note
30					

Weekly notes

Week	What repeated	What I will change
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		

Open notes

	Write in the lines

	Write in the lines

End of the month

Question	Your answer
What actually repeated?	
What did I abandon, and should it stay abandoned?	
What is the one change for next month?	
Do I need a person, not a PDF?	
Where is the file saved on my own device?	

- ☐ I can find this PDF without the download link.
- ☐ The license is mine. I have not posted the file.
- ☐ Next month's first action is written in one sentence.
- ☐ If the guide was the wrong tool, I know what I will do instead.

A last word

Use the pages that match the week you are actually having. Print a worksheet if paper helps you tell the truth. Put the file somewhere you can find it. And if a chapter tells you to talk to a licensed professional, that instruction outranks the rest of the PDF.